

Python on macOS

Python is not installed by default on the latest versions of macOS, so you'll need to install it if you haven't already done so. In this section, you'll install the latest version of Python, and then install VS Code and make sure it's configured correctly.

NOTE

Python 2 was included on older versions of macOS, but it's an outdated version that you shouldn't use.

Checking Whether Python 3 Is Installed

Open a terminal window by going to **Applications ▶ Utilities ▶ Terminal**. You can also press ⌘-spacebar, type **terminal**, and then press ENTER. To see if you have a recent enough version of Python installed, enter **python3**. You'll most likely see a message about installing the *command line developer tools*. It's better to install these tools after installing Python, so if this message appears, cancel the pop-up window.

If the output shows you have Python 3.9 or a later version installed, you can skip the next section and go to “Running Python in a Terminal Session.” If you see any version earlier than Python 3.9, follow the instructions in the next section to install the latest version.

Note that on macOS, whenever you see the `python` command in this book, you need to use the `python3` command instead to make sure you're using Python 3. On most macOS systems, the `python` command either points to an outdated version of Python that should only be used by internal system tools, or it points to nothing and generates an error message.

Installing the Latest Version of Python

You can find a Python installer for your system at <https://python.org>. Hover over the **Download** link, and you should see a button for downloading the latest version of Python. Click the button, which should automatically start downloading the correct installer for your system. After the file downloads, run the installer.

After the installer runs, a Finder window should appear. Double-click the *Install Certificates.command* file. Running this file will allow you to more easily install additional libraries that you'll need for real-world projects, including the projects in the second half of this book.

Running Python in a Terminal Session

You can now try running snippets of Python code by opening a new terminal window and typing **python3**:

```
$ python3
Python 3.x.x (v3.11.0:eb0004c271, Jun . . . , 10:03:01)
[Clang 13.0.0 (clang-1300.0.29.30)] on darwin
Type "help", "copyright", "credits" or "license" for more information.
>>>
```
